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Case Against UTEP

PHOENIX — This is a tale of two cities — El Paso and Phoenix.

It also is a contrast between one of the finest collegiate baseball programs in the country and one of the surriest.

The principals of this story are Arizona State University and Texas-El Paso.

The city of Phoenix, with a large assist from neighboring Tempe, treats ASU baseball like royalty. At ASU, as at Arizona, baseball is a showcase item. It is something to be proudly displayed, bringing national acclaim.

At UTEP, it seems, baseball is an unwanted child. It is something to push into the corner and forget about. It is in its infancy and shows no signs of growing up.

There is a clear comparison between ASU and UTEP.

Arizona made the expensive trip to El Paso two weeks ago and received one heck of a welcome — the same type of welcome the Tucson-Mexican Olympic Pavilion received.

Nobody was there.

In fact, there was a grand total of 49 spectators at Arizona's Friday game with UTEP (which didn't even outdraw the players). The good people of El Paso saved face Saturday, however, as a fine crowd of 97 clamored into Dudley Field.

"I didn't even know there were that many people there," said one UA official, who could have counted heads easily enough.

And the clincher: There's no admission charge at UTEP.

At the other extreme, 20,302 spectators paid their way into Phoenix Municipal Stadium last weekend to see ASU and UA conduct a three-game series. That figure includes a record-smashing 8,108 for Friday night's opener.

Dudley Field Is Ancient

UTEP's baseball program isn't first-class. Or second-class.

It has almost no class.

UTEP baseball is no credit to the growing Western Athletic Conference. Supposedly, baseball is big league in the WAC.

At UTEP, baseball hardly exists.

Perhaps, the most dreadful part of UTEP baseball is Dudley Field. This monstrosity, also the home of El Paso's AA professional team, was in existence more than three decades ago when UA coach Frank Sancet played for the Tucson Cowboys.

Dudley Field makes Bear Down Gym look like the Taj Mahal. This miserable excuse for a baseball field must have the lowest mound in the country. The infield is a lost cause, but the outfield at least has grass.

While Dudley Field wallows in its shameful physical decay, there are other essentials missing.

When Arizona played UTEP, there were no programs. The food was atrocious (luckily, there was nobody there to eat it). And, an assistant coach had to perform the job of public address announcer and official scorer.

It was all quite unbelievable.

Now, we come to UTEP baseball coach Andy Cohen.

Cohen, who is really a good coach, is the victim of blind justice. An old pro with a distinguished background in professional baseball, Cohen stepped in when UTEP added baseball to its program in 1963.

Cohen, fighting against big odds, has battled to bring respectability to Minor baseball. His brother, former major leaguer Sid Cohen, often assists with the UTEP pitchers. Assistant coach Krush Kruschwitz, an assistant professor in mathematics, has an interesting name, if nothing else.

But that isn't enough.

Call For Help

Cohen needs help. He needs scholarships (he has only one full scholarship now). He needs a practice field (his team works out at a high school field). He needs a replacement for Dudley Field. He even needs uniforms and batting helmets for his team.

It is fitting that Cohen is only a part-time employee at UTEP. It shows how bush the operation really is. (Cohen makes a living selling beer for an El Paso firm).

Perhaps, UTEP should realize that it has an obligation to the WAC to field a representative baseball team. Even if it doesn't feel an obligation to the fans around the league.

Clearly, help should be on the way for Cohen. He needs it — badly.

Arizona assistant coach Donnie Lee, talking about the fortunes of baseball, once said: "Baseball is a funny game. Some days it is hot, some days it is cold and some days it rains."

UTEP baseball is all wet — and it's time to do something about it.